Lesson 02 material: Dreams: Discussion, Listening and Reading

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

1.1: Discussion

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Answer the following questions based on your experience and opinion. Read five classmates' posts and respond to two classmates pointing out any similarities or differences, asking clarifying questions, or giving your opinion on a point they make.

1. Do you remember your dreams?
2. What languages are your dreams in?
3. Do you have recurring dreams? In other words, do you frequently dream about the same topic?
4. Do you think dreams have meanings? Why or why not?
5. Why do you think people dream?

1.2: Listening-Why Do We Dream?

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1.1.2.1. Exercise 1-Listening Comprehension

Watch the video Why Do We Dream? and build a basic understanding to prepare you for this chapter's reading. Answer the questions to check your comprehension.

1. Humans have discovered the definitive reason that we have dreams.
    a. True
    b. False
2. Known as The Father of Psychoanalysis, this doctor's theory of dreaming holds that the images in our dreams have symbolic meanings which relate to our subconscious wishes.
    a. Carl Jung
    b. Wilhelm Reich
    c. Sigmund Freud
    d. Hermann Rorschach
    e. Alfred Adler
3. The "Continuation Activation Theory" of dreams holds that you dream in order to:
    a. Keep your brain active when sensory input is low
    b. Figure out difficult problems from the day before
    c. All of the above
    d. Remember important things in the morning
    e. None of the above
4. Keeping your fight or flight instincts sharp is one of the reasons we dream, according to which theory?
    a. Continual Activation Theory
    b. Primitive Instinct Rehearsal Theory
    c. Reverse Learning Theory
    d. None of the above
    e. The Committee of Sleep Theory
5. According to the results of one research study, a person will be able to get through a 3D virtual maze the fastest on their second attempt at it if they:
    a. Take a nap but don't dream anything between their first and second attempts at getting through the 3D maze
    b. Think very hard about the 3D maze between their first and second attempts at getting through it
    c. Think of something entirely different between their first and second attempts at getting through the 3D maze
    d. Take a nap and dream about the 3D maze between the first and second attempt at getting through it
    e. Try harder the second time around

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Links on the original page

- Why Do We Dream?: https://www.ted.com/talks/amy_adkins_why_do_we_dream

1.3: Reading-The Story Behind Dreams

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

1.1.3.1. Exercise 2-Reading Comprehension

Read the passage below and answer the questions that follow.

1You walk into school and realize you forgot your math homework. Then, the teacher starts the lesson. Some of it makes sense, but some parts leave you scratching your head. You turn to the student next to you for help and realize it's your best friend who moved away in second grade. Then, you wake up. You were dreaming.

2Dreams can be exciting or terrifying. Often, they are complicated and confusing. And for much of human history, we've tried to make sense of them. The ancient Egyptians believed that dreams were messages from the gods. The ancient Greeks and Romans believed that dreams showed prophecies, or visions of the future. Later, in the 1800s, early psychologists believed that dreams centered on thoughts that people wanted to avoid, windows into what they called the "unconscious mind."

1.1.3.1.1. Why We Dream

3Today, scientists still aren't exactly sure why we have dreams, but a number of theories have emerged. One idea is that we dream to "practice" responding to problems. This is called "threat simulation theory" and might explain why our dreams so often involve stressful events such as forgetting your homework. Scientists believe that your brain might be preparing for how it would respond if you really do forget your homework. These scientists point out that humans aren't the only animals who dream; if you've ever seen a dog moving its legs while it's sleeping, it's probably dreaming about running.

4Another theory says that dreams play an important role in keeping people asleep. Scientists have long known that sleep produces a number of benefits for people's moods and long-term health. Dreams might allow people to get the sleep they need, theorizes South African scientist Mark Solms. He compares dreams to Saturday morning cartoons; your dreams keep your mind entertained so that the brain can do important work in the background — just like how cartoons keep small children entertained so that their parents are free to complete work around the house.

(Picture: Image 2 Photo by Torsten Dettlaff from Pexels)

Image 2 *Photo by* ***Torsten Dettlaff*** *from* ***Pexels***

5More recent advancements suggest that dreams could serve as a way for the brain to organize our thoughts and memories. Scientists in Germany proved this when they studied the electrical signals in the brains of sleeping mice. As the mice slept, the scientists found bursts of electricity in two sections of the brain: the neocortex, which controls thoughts, and the hippocampus, which controls memory. The scientists theorized their brains were sorting out which thoughts to store as memories and which to delete. If you've ever noticed that you forget most of your dreams, this could be why; most of your thoughts and experiences aren't kept as memories. "We dream to forget," said the scientist Francis Crick.

6However, some scientists still think that we dream for no reason at all. The "activation synthesis theory" says our dreams are random firings from memories, thoughts, and images within the brain. Supporters of this theory say that dreams don't provide advantages and don't have hidden meanings; they're just something that happens while we sleep. The "activation synthesis theory" states that the stories within our dreams largely come together within our brains after we wake up. The theory states the stories are formed only as we try to make sense our dreams' confusing twists and turns in the conscious state.

1.1.3.1.2. Benefits

7Regardless of why we dream, scientists agree that dreams can have many benefits. One group of scientists proved that dreams could help people solve complex problems. These scientists provided a group of people with a difficult-to-solve maze. Afterwards, they allowed the group members to take a break, with half of the participants being shown a video and the other half being told to nap. Ninety minutes later, everyone returned to the maze. In general, the nappers and the video-watchers performed about the same when they returned to the maze. But the nappers who reported dreaming about the maze were ten times better at completing it than anyone else.

8Dreams have also long been considered sources for inspiration. Paul McCartney, a former lead singer of the band The Beatles, said the idea for the famous song "Yesterday" came to him in a dream. He said he woke up thinking of the tune, and then immediately rushed to the piano to figure out the notes and write them down.

9Similarly, in the late 1600s, the philosopher and scientist René Descartes spent all day in a heated room, searching for the best way to come up with new knowledge. Without a solution at the end of the day, he put down his work and went to sleep. When he woke up, he recalled from his dreams the scientific method — the same process for experiments still taught in schools today.

1.1.3.1.3. Conclusions

10While scientists have many theories about why we dream, what we know for sure about them is still as hazy as dreams often are themselves. We know for sure that they are images collected from our brains' memory files. We know that for some people they can provide inspiration. Outside of that, a lot of what scientists think about dreams is just theorizing. Keep that in mind the next time you think you forgot your math homework at home.

1. PART A: Which statement best expresses the central idea of the text?
    a. People have different dreams for different reasons, making it difficult for scientists to answer the question "why do humans dream?"
    b. Most of the theories that scientists have about dreams show their benefits; however, there are no concrete conclusions for why humans dream.
    c. Scientists struggle to understand why people dream as there is currently no way to see what goes on in the brain when someone sleeps.
    d. Since humans are the only creatures that dream, scientists believe that dreaming is an important part of humans' advanced intelligence.
2. PART B: Which detail from the text best supports the answer to Part A?
    a. "You turn to the student next to you for help and realize it's your best friend who moved away in second grade. Then, you wake up. You were dreaming." (Paragraph 1)
    b. "Dreams can be exciting or terrifying. Often, they are complicated and confusing. And for much of human history, we've tried to make sense of them." (Paragraph 2)
    c. "The theory states the stories are formed only as we try to make sense our dreams' confusing twists and turns in the conscious state." (Paragraph 6)
    d. "Regardless of why we dream, scientists agree that dreams can have many benefits. One group of scientists proved that dreams could help people solve complex problems." (Paragraph 7)
3. What is the author's main purpose in the text?
    a. to explore the different theories that attempt to explain why humans dream
    b. to prove the benefits of searching for meaning in your dreams
    c. to criticize scientists for how little they know about why humans dream
    d. to support the idea that dreams prepare humans for problems in the real world
4. How does the author's discussion of Paul McCartney and René Descartes contribute to the development of ideas in the text (Paragraphs 8-9)?
    a. It shows how new and influential ideas can come from dreams.
    b. It proves that intelligent people tend to have more complex dreams.
    c. It demonstrates the importance of trying to understand our dreams.
    d. It supports the theory that your brain is organizing information as you sleep.

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Links on the original page

- The Story Behind Dreams: https://www.commonlit.org/en/texts/the-story-behind-your-dreams
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16.1: Chapter 1

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

4.1.1. Listening Comprehension

00:06 In the third millennium BCE,

00:08 Mesopotamian kings recorded and interpreted their dreams on wax tablets.

00:13 A thousand years later,

00:15 Ancient Egyptians wrote a dream book

00:17 listing over a hundred common dreams and their meanings.

00:20 And in the years since,

00:21 we haven't paused in our quest to understand why we dream.

00:25 So, after a great deal of scientific research,

00:28 technological advancement,

00:29 and persistence,

00:31 we still don't have any definite answers, but we have some interesting theories.

00:36 We dream to fulfill our wishes.

00:40 In the early 1900s,

00:42 Sigmund Freud proposed that while all of our dreams, including our nightmares,

00:46 are a collection of images from our daily conscious lives,

00:49 they also have symbolic meanings,

00:51 which relate to the fulfillment of our subconscious wishes.

00:55 Freud theorized that everything we remember when we wake up from a dream

00:59 is a symbolic representation

01:01 of our unconscious primitive thoughts, urges, and desires.

01:05 Freud believed that by analyzing those remembered elements,

01:08 the unconscious content would be revealed to our conscious mind,

01:12 and psychological issues stemming from its repression

01:14 could be addressed and resolved.

01:17 We dream to remember.

01:20 To increase performance on certain mental tasks,

01:23 sleep is good,

01:24 but dreaming while sleeping is better.

01:27 In 2010, researchers found

01:28 that subjects were much better at getting through a complex 3-D maze

01:32 if they had napped and dreamed of the maze prior to their second attempt.

01:37 In fact, they were up to ten times better at it

01:39 than those who only thought of the maze while awake between attempts,

01:44 and those who napped but did not dream about the maze.

01:48 Researchers theorize that certain memory processes

01:51 can happen only when we are asleep,

01:53 and our dreams are a signal that these processes are taking place.

01:58 We dream to forget.

02:02 There are about 10,000 trillion neural connections

02:05 within the architecture of your brain.

02:07 They are created by everything you think and everything you do.

02:11 A 1983 neurobiological theory of dreaming, called reverse learning,

02:15 holds that while sleeping, and mainly during REM sleep cycles,

02:19 your neocortex reviews these neural connections

02:22 and dumps the unnecessary ones.

02:25 Without this unlearning process,

02:27 which results in your dreams,

02:28 your brain could be overrun by useless connections

02:31 and parasitic thoughts could disrupt the necessary thinking

02:34 you need to do while you're awake.

02:37 We dream to keep our brains working.

02:42 The continual activation theory proposes that your dreams result

02:46 from your brain's need to constantly consolidate and create long-term memories

02:51 in order to function properly.

02:53 So when external input falls below a certain level,

02:55 like when you're asleep,

02:57 your brain automatically triggers

02:58 the generation of data from its memory storages,

03:01 which appear to you in the form of the thoughts and feelings

03:04 you experience in your dreams.

03:06 In other words,

03:07 your dreams might be a random screen saver your brain turns on

03:10 so it doesn't completely shut down.

03:14 We dream to rehearse.

03:18 Dreams involving dangerous and threatening situations are very common,

03:21 and the primitive instinct rehearsal theory

03:24 holds that the content of a dream is significant to its purpose.

03:27 Whether it's an anxiety-filled night of being chased through the woods by a bear

03:31 or fighting off a ninja in a dark alley,

03:34 these dreams allow you to practice your fight or flight instincts

03:37 and keep them sharp and dependable in case you'll need them in real life.

03:41 But it doesn't always have to be unpleasant.

03:43 For instance, dreams about your attractive neighbor

03:46 could actually give your reproductive instinct some practice, too.

03:50 We dream to heal.

03:54 Stress neurotransmitters in the brain are much less active

03:57 during the REM stage of sleep,

03:59 even during dreams of traumatic experiences,

04:02 leading some researchers to theorize

04:04 that one purpose of dreaming is to take the edge off painful experiences

04:08 to allow for psychological healing.

04:10 Reviewing traumatic events in your dreams with less mental stress

04:13 may grant you a clearer perspective

04:16 and enhanced ability to process them in psychologically healthy ways.

04:20 People with certain mood disorders and PTSD often have difficulty sleeping,

04:25 leading some scientists to believe that lack of dreaming

04:28 may be a contributing factor to their illnesses.

04:32 We dream to solve problems.

04:37 Unconstrained by reality and the rules of conventional logic,

04:40 in your dreams, your mind can create limitless scenarios

04:43 to help you grasp problems

04:45 and formulate solutions that you may not consider while awake.

04:49 John Steinbeck called it the committee of sleep,

04:51 and research has demonstrated

04:53 the effectiveness of dreaming on problem solving.

04:56 It's also how renowned chemist August Kekule

04:58 discovered the structure of the benzene molecule,

05:01 and it's the reason that sometimes the best solution for a problem

05:05 is to sleep on it.

05:06 And those are just a few of the more prominent theories.

05:10 As technology increases our capability for understanding the brain,

05:13 it's possible that one day

05:15 we will discover the definitive reason for them.

05:18 But until that time arrives, we'll just have to keep on dreaming.

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